Needs & Audience Analysis

Digital Literacy On-Ramp for Incarcerated Learners New to Tablet-Based Learning

1. Problem Statement

Course content on a secure learning platform assumes the learner can already operate the device it's delivered on — navigate a touchscreen, understand icons, recover from a mis-tap, and know what to do when something doesn't respond. For a meaningful portion of the justice-involved learner population, that assumption doesn't hold. Some learners have never used a touchscreen device. Others were incarcerated before smartphones were common and are encountering basic digital interaction patterns for the first time as adults. Treating digital-literacy onboarding as a solved problem — or skipping it entirely — creates a barrier before instructional content ever begins.

This analysis defines who these learners are, what specifically gets in their way, and what a course (or a short onboarding module preceding any course) needs to account for as a result.

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2. Learner Population

Who this covers

- Adults in jails and prisons using a shared or personal tablet for the first time, regardless of age.
- Long-sentence learners whose last experience with consumer technology predates touchscreens, app stores, or smartphones entirely.
- Learners with variable formal education levels, including those returning to structured learning after years or decades away from it.
- Learners for whom English may not be a first language, or whose reading level is below what course text assumes.
- Learners managing the psychological weight of incarceration itself, which affects attention, trust, and willingness to make visible mistakes in front of others.

What this analysis does not assume

- It does not assume digital unfamiliarity correlates with age. Younger learners without prior device access are just as likely to need onboarding as older learners.
- It does not assume low digital literacy means low intelligence, motivation, or capability. The gap is exposure, not aptitude.

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3. Key Constraints

No open internet	Every interaction pattern (search, back button behavior, link recognition) has to be taught inside the closed platform — learners can't fall back on general internet familiarity.
Shared or time-limited device access	Onboarding has to work in short sessions. A learner who loses their device slot mid-tutorial needs to resume without starting over or losing confidence.

No IT support on demand	Common tech friction (frozen screen, accidental exit, lost progress) needs an in-course recovery path, not a help desk to call.
High stakes for visible failure	Getting stuck in front of peers or facility staff can feel humiliating in a way that a typical adult learner setting doesn't carry. Errors need low-stakes, private recovery.
Facility-to-facility hardware variance	Screen size, tablet model, and even touch sensitivity may differ across facilities. Onboarding instructions can't assume a single device experience.

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4. Functional Needs

What a first-time or low-digital-literacy learner needs to be able to do before any course content becomes usable:

- Recognize and operate basic touch gestures: tap, swipe, scroll, press-and-hold — without assuming prior exposure to any of them.
- Understand common icon conventions (back arrow, menu, play/pause, checkmark) since icon literacy is itself a learned skill, not universal.
- Know how to recover from a mistake — going back, undoing a selection, exiting a screen — without fear that a wrong tap breaks something or costs progress.
- Understand what "auto-save" or "progress saved" means, since trusting invisible system behavior is itself a literacy gap for someone new to software.
- Locate where they are in a course and how much is left, in plain visual terms (progress bar, screen count) without relying on navigation metaphors from apps they've never used.

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5. Psychological & Trauma-Informed Needs

- Privacy in failure: mistakes during onboarding should never be visible to other learners or staff by default. No public leaderboards or shared error states during a skills-building phase.
- No punitive framing for slowness: a learner moving through onboarding more slowly than another is not a deficiency to flag — pacing needs to stay ungated and uncompared.
- Plain, non-clinical language: avoid instructional language that reads as condescending ("don't worry, this is easy!") or clinical ("complete this module to demonstrate competency"). Neutral, respectful, adult-to-adult phrasing throughout.
- Control over pace and repetition: a learner should be able to repeat a tutorial step as many times as needed without any record of "how many tries it took" surfacing anywhere they can see or that staff can see.
- Dignity in the framing of "new to this": onboarding content should never imply the learner is behind, lesser, or catching up — only that this is where every learner starts on this platform.

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6. Design Implications

These needs translate into concrete requirements for any course built on top of this population's reality:

- A short, optional but strongly-suggested device/navigation tutorial before the first real course content, not folded silently into lesson one.

- Icons paired with plain-language text labels throughout, never icon-only navigation.
- Generous tap targets and forgiving touch sensitivity assumptions, since fine motor precision with an unfamiliar touchscreen is a real variable.
- No hidden gestures required to progress (e.g., swipe-to-reveal) without an equally visible tappable alternative.
- Explicit, visible confirmation of saved progress ("Saved" or a checkmark), since invisible auto-save is a trust assumption this audience hasn't necessarily built yet.
- Reading level check on all instructional copy — plain language throughout, not just in content screens but in every button label and system message.

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7. Open Questions / Assumptions to Validate

This analysis is built from population characteristics and general adult-learning and trauma-informed design principles. Items that would need validation against actual platform analytics or facility staff input before finalizing a course:

- Actual device models and screen sizes in current circulation across facilities.
- Whether onboarding completion data is currently tracked, and whether any of it is visible to facility staff in ways that could feel surveillant to learners.
- Average session length and interruption frequency, to calibrate how short onboarding segments need to be.
- Existing reading-level data across the learner population, to set a defensible plain-language target rather than an assumed one.